

Chapter 4_Unity of Ummah

A'l "Imran : V: 103

وَاعْتَصِمُوا بِحَبْلِ اللَّهِ جَمِيعًا وَلَا تَفَرَّقُوا ۚ وَادْكُرُوا نِعْمَتَ اللَّهِ عَلَيْكُمْ إِذْ كُنْتُمْ أَعْدَاءً فَأَلَّفَ بَيْنَ قُلُوبِكُمْ فَأَصْبَحْتُمْ بِنِعْمَتِهِ إِخْوَانًا وَكُنْتُمْ عَلَى شَفَا حُفْرَةٍ مِنَ النَّارِ فَأَنْقَذَكُمْ مِنْهَا ۚ كَذَلِكَ يُبَيِّنُ اللَّهُ لَكُمْ آيَاتِهِ لَعَلَّكُمْ تَهْتَدُونَ ﴿١٠٣﴾ (آل عمران: 103)

Explanation

- In the two verses appearing here, two important principles have been given which go to make the collective strength of Muslims impregnable. These are 1) taqwa and 2) unity.
- The first principle appears in verse no 102 of al Imran. The second principle "Unity" follows in the second verse. The first principle stated in the said verse is that one must 'fear Allah', that is, one should **organize** and manage his life with a full sense of responsibility before Allah, avoiding all that is forbidden or undesirable, doing so in a manner 'which is His due'.
- In the second verse **وَاعْتَصِمُوا بِحَبْلِ اللَّهِ جَمِيعًا** (And hold on to the cord of Allah, all of you), the golden principle of unity has been presented with great eloquence and wisdom, for the principle, being the only effective binding factor, has been identified before the command to unite was given, following which, came the prohibition of disunity and chaos **وَلَا تَفَرَّقُوا** .
- Elaborating this a little, it can be said that unity is something good and desirable, a premise generally approved by all human beings, no matter what place, time, religion or life style they adhere to. A person who considers fights and disputes as something useful, and good in themselves, would be hard to find anywhere. This is why all groups and parties around the world invariably ask people to unite.
- Therefore, the Holy Qur'in has not stopped at giving sermons on unity and order, instead, it has also come forward with a just principle which would help achieve and sustain the desired state of affairs in the world, something in which no group should find a ground for differences. The truth of the matter is that imposing a system or programme conceived by one or some members of the human race on other human beings, and hoping that all of them will accept it unanimously, is simply against commonsense, and justice, and is nothing but cheeky self-deception. However, the system and the programme given by the Creator-Sustainer of all the worlds, is something all human beings should naturally agree upon. No rational human being can deny it on principle.

- The Holy Qur'an, in the present verse, shows us the way as to how we can eliminate this tendency to become divided when it says: **وَاعْتَصِمُوا بِحَبْلِ اللَّهِ جَمِيعًا** And hold on to the cord of Allah, all of you. Here, (the cord of Allah) means **the Holy Qur'an**. The blessed Companion, 'Abdullah ibn Mas'ud is the narrator of the *hadith* in which the Holy Prophet has been reported to have said:

The Book of Allah is the cord of Allah, extended from the heavens to the earth.

- In another narration of the *hadith* by the noble Companion, Zayd ibn Arqam, the words are: “**The cord of Allah is the Qur'an**” (Ibn Kathir)
- In Arabic usage, the word, '*habl*' also means 'covenant' and, in an absolute sense, it covers everything that can be used as a connecting link. The metaphor of 'cord' has been used for the Qur'an or the Faith to suggest that this is the connecting link which, on one side, establishes the lines of communion between those who believe and their Lord, while, on the other side, it brings all those who believe close together, forming one group.
- Also present here is a subtle analogy focused on Muslims holding fast to the Book of Allah. Their effort resembles the effort of those who would grip a strong rope while climbing and thus remain protected against a fall.
- Before we move on to the second part of the verse, let us remember the two distinct instructions given to Muslims in this verse, that is, they should first live by the system prescribed for them by Allah Almighty, then, they should hold fast to 'the cord of Allah' all together. This is how the Muslim ummah gained ascendance in the past and there is no reason why, it will not rise again.
- This far the discussion revolved around the positive aspect of unity among Muslims. The text now takes up the negative aspect when it says: **وَلَا تَفَرَّقُوا** (And do not be divided). This is another example of the peculiarly wise style of the Holy Qur'an when it would highlight the positive aspect first, then identify the negative, and forbid the later.
- Since disunity is the first and the last reason behind the destruction of a nation, therefore, the Holy Qur'an has repeatedly forbidden it in ways. **The Holy Prophet (SAWW) has said** that there are three things Allah Almighty has liked for you while there are three others He has disliked. **The ones He has liked are as follows:**
 1. That your worship should be for Allah alone and that you should not attribute partners to His divinity.
 2. That you should hold on to the Book of Allah firmly and avoid disunity.
 3. That you should have goodwill for those in authority from among you.**The three things which cause Allah's displeasure are:**
 1. Unnecessary argumentation.
 2. Needless asking.

3. Wastage of resources.

(Ibn Kathir from Abi Hurairah)

- The text, after making the two aspects of unity clear, points out to the conditions prevailing among pre-Islam Arabs. Because of tribal rivalries, incessant warfare and long-drawn blood feuds, the entire nation was on the brink of total ruin. What saved them from the fire of hatred was nothing but this blessings of Islam. So, it was said: And remember the blessing of Allah upon you: When you were enemies to each other, and He brought your hearts together, then you, with His grace, became brothers. And you were at the brink of a pit of the Fire, then, He saved you from it. (103)
- In other words, by erasing out deep-seated enmities going back to centuries, Allah Almighty made them brothers to each other through the benediction of Islam and the noble Prophet (SAWW). This made their life worth living, materially and spiritually, establishing between them such exemplary friendship that even their enemies found it awesome.
- It also follows from here that for Muslims, if they desire to have a stable organization among them, and unity, the only alternative open is that they should make obedience to Allah their life style. This point has been hinted at towards the end of the verse where it was said: This is how Allah makes His signs clear to you, so that you may take the right path.

(Al Hujura't verse 10)

إِنَّمَا الْمُؤْمِنُونَ إِخْوَةٌ فَأَصْلَحُوا بَيْنَ أَخَوَيْكُمْ ۚ وَاتَّقُوا اللَّهَ لَعَلَّكُمْ تُرْحَمُونَ ﴿١٠﴾ (الحجرات: 10)

Explanation

- **Occasion of Revelation**

The commentators have narrated several incidents as a background of the revelation of these verses. Among them is the clash that took place between two Muslim groups. It is not inconceivable that the totality of these incidents might have been the occasion of revelation. It is also possible that one of these incidents has been the cause of revelation and the other incidents, being similar, were also termed as the occasion of revelation.

- Although the immediate addressees of this verse are rulers and those in authority who have the means to fight and wage war, [as stated by Abii Hayyan i n Al-Bahr] all Muslims are

addressed in this verse indirectly to assist those in authority in this matter. Where there is no leader, 'amir, king or president, the rule is that, the two warring parties should be advised, as far as possible, to cease war. If this is not possible, common people are

ordered to stay away from both warring groups: they should neither oppose nor aid any one of them.

- It means that if the belligerent party ceases fighting, then do not only stop fighting but also think about eliminating the cause of war and mutual dissatisfaction, so that the heart-burnings may come to an end. All enmity and hostilities will thus cease and an atmosphere of brotherhood may prevail for all times to come.
- There is a Hadith in the Sahih in which Anas (R.A.) states that the Messenger of Allah (SAWW) said,

«اَنْصُرْ اَخَاكَ ظَالِمًا اَوْ مَظْلُومًا»

(Help your brother, whether he is an oppressor or he is oppressed.) "I asked, 'O Allah's Messenger! It is right that I help him if he is oppressed, but how should I help him if he is an oppressor' He said,

«تَمْنَعُهُ مِنَ الظُّلْمِ فَذَاكَ نَصْرُكَ اِيَّاهُ»

(By preventing him from oppressing others; this is how you help him in this case.)"

- Sa'id bin Jubayr said that tribes of Aws and Khazraj once got in a scuffle using date tree branches and slippers. Allah revealed this honorable Ayah commanding them to make peace between them. As-Suddi said, "A man from Al-Ansar, whose name was `Imran, had a wife called Umm Zayd. She wanted to visit her family, but her husband prevented her from visiting them by locking her in an upper room. So, none of her family could visit or see her. She sent someone to her family. They came, took her down from the room and wanted to take her away. Her husband was absent at the time, so his family called on their people. Their cousins came to help prevent the wife from going with her family. A push and shove situation occurred that led to them fighting using slippers. This Ayah was then revealed in their case, and the Messenger of Allah sent someone to bring peace between them, and they both agreed to resort to the decision of Allah the Exalted." The statement of Allah the Exalted, next,
- The Messenger of Allah (SAWW) said, **(The Muslim is the brother of the Muslim, he is not unjust with him nor does he forsake him.)** In the Sahih, **Allah helps the servant as long as the servant helps his brother.)** Also in the Sahih: **(If the Muslim invokes Allah for the benefit of his absent brother, the angel says afterwards, "Amin, and for you the same.")** There are many Hadiths with this meaning, such as, in the Sahih, **(The parable of the believers in relation to the kindness, mercy and compassion they have for each other, is that of the body: when an organ of it falls ill, the rest of the body responds with fever and sleeplessness.)** And also in Sahih. **(A believer to another believer is like a building whose different parts enforce each other.)** **The Prophet then clasped his hands with the fingers interlaced.**
- Allah's statement, **فَاَصْلِحُوا بَيْنَ أَخَوَيْكُمْ** (So make reconciliation between your brothers,) refers to the two groups that fight each other,

- **وَ اتَّقُوا اللَّهَ** (and have Taqwa of Allah) in all of your affairs,
- **لَعَلَّكُمْ تُرْحَمُونَ** (that you may receive mercy.) and this is a promise from Allah that He will grant mercy to those who fear and obey Him.

(Al Imran verse no 64)

قُلْ يَا أَهْلَ الْكِتَابِ تَعَالَوْا إِلَى كَلِمَةٍ سَوَاءٍ بَيْنَنَا وَبَيْنَكُمْ أَلَّا نَعْبُدَ إِلَّا اللَّهَ وَلَا نُشْرِكَ بِهِ شَيْئًا وَلَا يَتَّخِذَ بَعْضُنَا بَعْضًا أَرْبَابًا مِنْ دُونِ اللَّهِ فَإِنْ تَوَلَّوْا فَقُولُوا اشْهَدُوا بِأَنَّا مُسْلِمُونَ ﴿٦٤﴾ (آل عمران: 64)

Explanation

- **Preceding verse:** The reason for the call to Mubahalalah and the revelation of the Ayat from the beginning of this Surah until here, is that a delegation from the Christians of Najran (in Yemen) came to Al-Madinah to argue about `Isa, claiming that he was divine and the son of Allah. Allah sent down the beginning of this Surah until here, to refute their claims, as Imam Muhammad bin Ishaq bin Yasar and other scholars stated. The Christians sent a delegation to the Holy Prophet (SAWW) consisting of Shurahbil 'Ahdullah b. Shurahh bil and Jabbar ibn Fayd to the Holy Prophet (SAWW). They came and began their talks on religious issues. When they, in their effort to prove the godhood of Jesus, took their debate to the extremes of dispute, that was the moment this verse of *Mubahala* was revealed. Thereupon, the Holy Prophet (SAWW) invited the Christians to join in the *Mubahala* confrontation (a form of resolving disputes by praying to Allah) and quite readily, he himself came out with Sayyidah Fatimah (R.A.) , Sayyidna '**Ali (R.A.)** and their sons, Hasan and Husain (R.A.) , along with him all set for the *Mubahalalah*. Looking at this, Shurahbil said to his two comrades: 'Look, you already know that he is a prophet of Allah and getting into a *MubZhalah* confrontation with a prophet means certain death and destruction for us. So find out some other way to get out of this fix.' His comrades asked him as to what he thought it could be. Shurahbil said: 'I think the best solution is to opt for a truce as advised by the prophet'. So, on this everybody agreed. As a result, the Holy Prophet (SAWW). made peace by fixing a levy on them which was accepted by them as well. (Tafsir ibn Kathir, V. 1)
- **The meaning of Mubahalalah:** As stated earlier, verse 61 has instructed the Holy Prophet & to invite his opponents (Christians) to *Mubahuluh* which literally means 'mutual prayer' but in the terminology of Islamic Shari'ah it refers to a particular form of resolving religious disputes. When the argumentations from both sides fail to resolve a religious issue, the parties jointly pray Allah to cast His curse on whichever of the two parties is false. Since curse means 'moving someone far away from the divine mercy', - and moving far away from mercy is being close to divine wrath-- therefore, the essence of the meaning is: Wrath be on the liar. As such, whoever is the liar shall face the evil

consequences whereupon the truth will become evident before the disbelievers as well. Invocation in this manner is called 'Mubihalah'.

- This verse: **تَعَالَوْا إِلَى كَلِمَةٍ سَوَاءٍ بَيْنَنَا وَبَيْنَكُمْ** unfolds an important principle of *Tabligh* (Preaching) and *Da'wah* (Preaching Islam). The principle requires that a person, who desires to carry his call to a group which holds beliefs and ideas different from his own, should follow a particular method. That method is to induce that group to unite only on what they both can agree to, for instance, when the Holy Prophet & gave **the** Byzantine ruler, Hiraql (Heraclius) the call to Islam, he picked up **a** particular point on which there was mutual agreement, i.e., on the Oneness of Allah Almighty.
- This Ayah includes the People of the Book, the Jews and Christians, and those who follow their ways.
- **كَلِمَةٍ** 'Word' - in Arabic - also means a complete sentence, as evident from this Ayah. Allah described this word as being one,
- that is the same between us and you), an honest and righteous word that is fair to both parties. Allah then explained this word.
- (that we worship none but Allah (Alone), and that we associate no partners with Him,) we worship neither a statue, cross, idol, Taghut (false gods), fire or anything else. Rather, we worship Allah Alone without partners, and this is the message of all of Allah's Messengers.
- ("and that none of us shall take others as lords besides Allah.") Ibn Jurayj commented, "We do not obey each other in disobedience to Allah."
- (Then, if they turn away, say: "Bear witness that we are Muslims.") if they abandon this fair call, then let them know that you will remain in Islam as Allah has legislated for you.
- **فَقُولُوا اشْهَدُوا بِأَنَّا مُسْلِمُونَ** in the last sentence of the verse teaches us a lesson, that is, should someone refuse to accept the truth, even after it has been proved clearly, then the proper course is to restate one's own belief and conclude the conversation. Entering into further debate and verbal altercation is not appropriate.
- Muhammad bin Ishaq and other scholars said that the beginning of Surah Al `Imran, and more than eighty verses thereafter; were revealed about the delegation of Najran. Az-Zuhri stated that the people of Najran were the first people to pay the Jizyah (tax money paid to the Muslim State).

(Al Ana'm verse no 108)

وَلَا تَسُبُّوا الَّذِينَ يَدْعُونَ مِنْ دُونِ اللَّهِ فَيَسُبُّوا اللَّهَ عَدْوًا بِغَيْرِ عِلْمٍ ۚ كَذَلِكَ زَيْنًا لِكُلِّ أُمَّةٍ عَمَلُهُمْ ثُمَّ إِلَىٰ رَبِّهِمْ مَرْجِعُهُمْ فَيُنَبِّئُهُمْ بِمَا كَانُوا يَعْمَلُونَ ﴿١٠٨﴾ (الأنعام:108)

Explanation

- The present verses has been revealed concerning a particular event and provides guidance in a matter of principle, that is, what you are not permitted to do yourself, for that you cannot become the cause or channel either - both shall remain equally impermissible.
- **The Background of Revelation**
According to the background of revelation as narrated by Ibn Jarir, when Abu Tilib, the respected uncle of the Holy Prophet (SAWW) was on his death bed, the disbelieving chiefs of the tribe of Quraysh who, hostile and torturous to the Holy Prophet (SAWW), **and** always plotting to kill him, became alarmed at the eventuality of the death of A b i Tilib which was likely to become an impediment to their nefarious designs. Because, they thought, if they were to kill Muhammad (SAWW) after his protective uncle's death, that would go against the norms of their own self-respect and honour, for people would say that they were unable to do anything like that in the presence of Abi Talib, but when he died, they killed his helpless nephew. So, they decided to get together and go to Abi Tilib to talk about the matter in a decisive manner.
- Revealed, thereupon, was the verse: **وَلَا تَسُبُّوا الَّذِينَ يَدْعُونَ مِنْ دُونِ اللَّهِ فَيَسُبُّوا اللَّهَ عَدْوًا بِغَيْرِ عِلْمٍ**
- **لَا تَسُبُّوا** In this verse is a derivation from the word: (sabb) which means to abuse or use insulting language against someone.
- Allah prohibits His Messenger and the believers from insulting the false deities of the idolators, although there is a clear benefit in doing so. Insulting their deities will lead to a bigger evil than its benefit, for the idolators might retaliate by insulting the God of the believers, Allah, none has the right to be worshipped but He. `Ali bin Abi Talhah said that Ibn `Abbas commented on this Ayah }6:108{; "They (disbelievers) said, 'O Muhammad! You will stop insulting our gods, or we will insult your Lord.' Thereafter, Allah prohibited the believers from insulting the disbelievers' idols,
- **(lest they insult Allah wrongfully without knowledge.)**" `Abdur-Razzaq narrated that Ma`mar said that Qatadah said, "Muslims used to insult the idols of the disbelievers and the disbelievers would retaliate by insulting Allah wrongfully without knowledge. Allah revealed,
- **(And insult not those whom they worship besides Allah.)**" On this same subject -- abandoning what carries benefit to avert a greater evil, Becoming the Cause or Agent of a Sin is also a Sin.
- **(Thus We have made fair seeming to each people its own doings;)** means, as We made fair seeming to the idolators loving their idols and defending them, likewise We made fair seeming to every previous nation the misguidance they indulged in. Allah's is the most perfect proof, and the most complete wisdom in all that He wills and chooses.
- **(then to their Lord is their return,)** gathering and final destination,
- **(and He shall then inform them of all that they used to do.)** He will compensate them for their deeds, good for good and evil for evil.
- To sum up, it can be said that, no word which could be taken as abusive was ever said by the Holy Prophet (SAWW), or had appeared in the Holy Qur'an, nor was there any apprehension that it could happen in the future. Of course, the probability that Muslims at large may fall into such impulsive action did exist, therefore, this verse stopped them from doing so.

